(Link: www.nhs.uk/)

Naproxen

Naproxen is a painkiller that helps relieve pain and reduce swelling (inflammation). You can buy some types from pharmacies, but others are only available with a prescription.

What naproxen is for

Naproxen is a type of painkiller called a non-steroidal anti-inflammatory drug (NSAID (Link: www.nhs.uk/medicines/nsaids/)).

Naproxen can help with lots of types of pain and conditions that cause inflammation, including:

- period pain
- joint and muscle pain
- gout
- osteoarthritis
- rheumatoid arthritis

How to take naproxen

Naproxen usually comes as tablets or a liquid that you swallow. There's also a type of tablet that you dissolve in water and drink (effervescent tablets).

It's usually taken up to 3 times a day.

How much you should take and for how long depends on which type it is and why you're taking it.

Always check the packet or leaflet that comes with your medicine. Ask a pharmacist or doctor for advice if you're not sure how to take it or have any problems taking it.

When taking naproxen:

- swallow tablets whole with water – do not chew or crush tablets labelled "gastro-resistant" or "film-coated"
- if you're taking effervescent tablets, let the tablet dissolve in a glass of water before swallowing it
- use the cup or spoon that comes with the liquid to help you measure the right dose
- ideally naproxen should be taken with or after food, to help protect your stomach

Your doctor may also prescribe a second medicine, such as omeprazole (Link: www.nhs.uk/medicines/omeprazole/). This can help protect your stomach while you're taking naproxen.

Important

To reduce the risk of side effects, take the smallest dose you need for the shortest time you need it.

Do not take naproxen for longer than 3 days if you bought it without a prescription. See a GP if your symptoms get worse or do not get better.

If you miss a dose of naproxen

If you forget to take dose of naproxen, take it as soon as you remember.

If it's nearly time for your next dose, skip the dose you missed and take your next dose at the usual time.

Do not take 2 doses at the same time to make up for a missed dose.

If you take too much naproxen

Taking an extra dose of naproxen is unlikely to cause problems, but it's important to get medical advice if you take too much as it can sometimes be dangerous.

Speak to a pharmacist as soon as possible if:

- you've taken more naproxen than it says on the packet, leaflet or prescription

If you're unable to speak to a pharmacist, or you took too much of your medicine on purpose, call NHS 111 for advice.

Find a pharmacy (Link: https://www.nhs.uk/service-search/pharmacy/find-a-pharmacy/)

If you're told to go to A&E, do not drive. Ask someone to drive you or call 999 and ask for an ambulance.

Bring the naproxen packet or leaflet inside it, any remaining medicine, and any other medicines you take.

Side effects of naproxen

Like all medicines, naproxen can cause side effects, although not everyone gets them.

Common side effects

Common side effects of naproxen include:

- constipation or diarrhoea
- dizziness
- feeling sleepy or tired
- bloating and stomach pain
- headaches
- feeling sick (nausea) or being sick (vomiting)
- a rash
- ringing in your ears (tinnitus)

Naproxen will not usually affect your ability to drive, ride a bike or use machinery, but if you feel dizzy, tired or have problems with your vision after taking it, wait until you no longer have these side effects.

Speak to a pharmacist or doctor if:

- you have any side effects that bother you or do not go away

They may be able to give you advice about how you can reduce side effects.

Find a pharmacy (Link: https://www.nhs.uk/service-search/pharmacy/find-a-pharmacy/)

Serious side effects

Naproxen can sometimes cause serious side effects, although many of them are rare.

Possible serious side effects of naproxen include:

- stomach ulcers (Link: www.nhs.uk/conditions/stomach-ulcer/) or bleeding inside your stomach – causing symptoms such as tummy pain, bloating, shortness of breath, looking paler than normal, poo that's black, sticky and tar-like, or vomiting blood
- a problem with your kidneys – causing symptoms such as shortness of breath, blood in your pee, or swelling in your ankles, feet or hands

- problems with your blood – causing symptoms such as a slow, irregular heartbeat, lots of sore throats, nosebleeds, infections, and feeling breathless or more tired than normal
- heart failure (Link: www.nhs.uk/conditions/heart-failure/) – causing symptoms such feeling breathless or more tired than normal, and swelling in your legs and ankles
- an allergic reaction (anaphylaxis (Link: www.nhs.uk/conditions/anaphylaxis/)) – causing symptoms such as a swollen throat or tongue, a raised, itchy rash or difficulty breathing

The risk of serious side effects is higher if you're taking a high dose of naproxen or taking it for a long time.

Call NHS 111 if:

- you're taking naproxen and think you might be having serious side effects

More about side effects

These are not all the side effects of naproxen.

For a full list, see the leaflet that comes with your medicine or search for your medicine leaflet on the electronic medicines compendium website (Link: https://www.medicines.org.uk/emc).

You can report any side effects you get on the Yellow Card website (Link: https://yellowcard.mhra.gov.uk/)

Who can and cannot take naproxen

Most adults can take naproxen. Some types can also be given to children from 5 years old.

But naproxen is not suitable for everyone. For example, it may not be suitable if:

- you've had an allergic reaction to or serious side effect from naproxen, ibuprofen (Link: www.nhs.uk/medicines/ibuprofen-for-adults/), aspirin (Link: www.nhs.uk/medicines/aspirin/) or another non-steroidal anti-inflammatory drug (NSAID (Link: www.nhs.uk/medicines/nsaids/))
- you have a stomach ulcer or you've had them before
- you have a heart, liver or kidney condition
- you have asthma or allergies (such as hay fever)
- you have problems with blood clotting

- you've had a stroke
- you have Crohn's disease or ulcerative colitis
- you're pregnant or trying to get pregnant

Check the packet or leaflet that comes with your medicine to see if it's suitable for you. Speak to a pharmacist or doctor if you're not sure if you can take it.

Breastfeeding and naproxen

If you're breastfeeding, tell your doctor or pharmacist before taking naproxen.

Naproxen is not usually used while breastfeeding because the medicine can pass into your breast milk in small amounts.

Other NSAIDs, such as ibuprofen (Link: www.nhs.uk/medicines/ibuprofen-for-adults/), are safer to take if you're breastfeeding.

But your doctor may recommend taking naproxen if the benefits to you outweigh any possible risks to your baby.

It's rare for breastfed babies to get any side effects from medicine you're taking, but speak to a healthcare professional if you have any concerns about your baby.

Pregnancy and naproxen

You should avoid taking naproxen during pregnancy unless you're advised to by a doctor or pharmacist.

Paracetamol is usually the best painkiller to take if you're pregnant.

Find out more about taking naproxen during pregnancy on the Bumps (Best Use of Medicines in Pregnancy) website (Link: https://www.medicinesinpregnancy.org/leaflets-a-z/naproxen/)

Taking naproxen with other medicines, food and drink

There are some medicines, remedies and supplements that may not mix well with naproxen.

These include some types of:

- anticoagulants (Link: www.nhs.uk/medicines/anticoagulants/), such as warfarin (Link: www.nhs.uk/medicines/warfarin/)
- steroid medicines (Link: www.nhs.uk/medicines/steroids/), such as prednisolone (Link: www.nhs.uk/medicines/prednisolone/)
- antidepressants (Link: www.nhs.uk/medicines/antidepressants/), such as citalopram (Link: www.nhs.uk/medicines/citalopram/)
- medicines that make you pee more (diuretics), such as furosemide (Link: www.nhs.uk/medicines/furosemide/)
- medicines to treat heart problems and high blood pressure, such as enalapril (Link: www.nhs.uk/medicines/enalapril/)

- medicines to treat rheumatoid arthritis, such as methotrexate (Link: www.nhs.uk/medicines/methotrexate/)

Check the packet or leaflet that comes with your medicine to see if it's suitable for you. Speak to a pharmacist or doctor if you're not sure if you can take it.

Taking naproxen with other painkillers

Naproxen can be taken at the same time as paracetamol or co-codamol (Link: www.nhs.uk/medicines/co-codamol-for-adults/) if needed for a short time, but speak to a doctor or pharmacist first.

Do not take naproxen at the same time as other non-steroidal anti-inflammatory drugs (NSAIDs), such as ibuprofen or aspirin. This can increase the risk of serious side effects like stomach ulcers.

Food, drink and alcohol with naproxen

You can eat and drink normally while taking naproxen, but try to limit how much alcohol you drink while taking it because alcohol can increase the risk of side effects such as stomach ulcers or bleeding.

Find out more about your medicine

To find out more about your medicine, you can:

- check the leaflet that comes with it
- search for your medicine leaflet on the electronic medicines compendium website (Link: https://www.medicines.org.uk/)
- speak to a pharmacist or doctor for advice

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